We will remember him in connection with the turncoat C. Thambusami Pillai. Born circa 1870, Vedamurthi Mudaliar was a graduate and a landlord from Alwarkurichi, a fertile village in the Tamiraparani basin near Tirunelveli. He began his career as a pen pusher as a sub-registrar in Tirunelveli and became municipal secretary in Tuticorin. Attracted by journalism, he took to editing and publishing two journals from Tirunelveli: *Sarvajana Mitran* in Tamil (discontinued in April 1906) and *The People's Guardian* in English. Sometime in early 1907, he secured appointment as a secretary in SSNCo and consequently gave up publishing the two journals. Evidently, he was known to VOC some years before the beginning of the Swadeshi movement; I have been able to trace a few general essays that he published in the first volume of *Vivekabhanu* (1900), the scholarly monthly that VOC had promoted and patronized. In late 1906, he had set up 'a swadeshi museum for industrial articles, etc.' but it folded up after he left for France to purchase the steamers.[52]

Why did VOC assign this important task to Vedamurthi Mudaliar rather than go himself? Possibly, he did not see himself qualified for this task. But there is little to show that Vedamurthi Mudaliar was any better qualified. As we shall see, the steamers broke down frequently and unseemly talk rife about their poor quality. VOC and Vedamurthi Mudaliar had a falling out on this issue.[53]

Whatever be the quality of the steamers, by early 1907, SSNCo managed to acquire its own steamers: the *Gallia* and the *Lawoe*. This was no mean achievement.

From VOC's letter to *Swadesamitran*, reproduced in *India*, we know that the *Gallia* was bought on 22 December 1906, and the *Lawoe* on 24 January 1907.[54] Apart from the steamers, *Miranda*, a steam launch which could ferry 200 passengers, was purchased as well.[55]

How much did these vessels cost? There were bound to be conflicting reports on the price. Since steamers were complex commodities with a range of costs and expenses involved—not to speak of intermediaries—this was not surprising.